THE LETTER TO THE FATHER

An Original Prestige Feature

Proposed: Adrien Brody as Franz Kafka (unattached)

Logline
In the final years of his life, a frail and tormented Franz Kafka struggles to write, love, and exist within a world of family pressure, bureaucratic humiliation, illness, and spiritual dread — while the stories he creates begin to mirror and consume the life he can no longer control.

The Film
A six-movement prestige drama built around the central wound of Kafka's life: the father he could never confront directly. Not a conventional literary biopic but a controlled, formally ambitious portrait in which family life, office bureaucracy, love affairs, illness, and authorship all tighten around the same sentence. The recurring Kraus sawmill case, the undelivered Letter to His Father, and the brief late-life Berlin happiness with Dora Diamant give the film a cleaner dramatic spine, a stronger title hook, and a more emotional final movement than standard "great writer" material.

Why Adrien Brody
This role is engineered for what Brody does better than any working actor: inwardness, physical fragility, silence with performance gravity, and the ability to make thought, shame, wit, and endurance visible at once. The part now spans public competence at the Insurance Institute, romantic terror across three radically different relationships, a philosophical duel with Max Brod over whether the work should survive him, and a final act of physical ruin and mental clarity. Following *The Brutalist*, it reads as the apex role of this career phase.

Comparable Films
The Pianist · Amadeus · Phantom Thread · A Serious Man · Tár · First Reformed · The Lives of Others · A Hidden Life

Production Profile
Budget range: $12–18M. Period drama (Prague/Berlin, 1912–1924) with contained cast and locations, an interior-heavy 50–55 day schedule, and an incentive-backed European production plan. Designed for ultra-premium indie or prestige streamer financing. International co-production friendly (Czech Republic, Germany, Austria).

Festival & Awards Path
Targeting Venice or Cannes premiere → Telluride/TIFF → fall platform release → full Oscar campaign. Best Actor as primary category, with strong positioning for Screenplay, Director, and Cinematography.

Key Scenes
Six major awards-clip scenes including: Kafka coughing blood outside a butcher's window; a bureaucratic elevator ride that plays like metaphysical damnation; an engagement dinner staged as a tribunal; the never-delivered Letter to His Father returning to Berlin years later; a "burn everything" confrontation with Max Brod about whether unfinished work belongs to the world; and a devastating final act of handwritten slips, physical collapse, and spiritual clarity.

"What if Kafka's life itself became a Kafka story?"

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.